The Guardian

one stop english

How to quit fast fashion: 'Sometimes we don't need retail therapy, we need actual therapy'

Level 3: Intermediate

1 Warmer

a. Read the definitions below. Then, discuss the questions with a partner.

fast fashion: cheap clothing produced quickly and sold in large quantities to respond to the latest fashion trends

mass production: the process of producing large quantities of goods by using machines

retail therapy: the activity of shopping to make yourself feel happier

- Do you think *retail therapy* really makes you happier?
- How often do you think people should ideally buy new clothes? How can people buy less?
- Why is the mass production of clothes bad for the environment?
- How can people quit *fast fashion*?

2 Key words

a. Choose the word from the article that best matches each definition.

1. an adjective meaning *noticing that something exists or is happening and realizing that it is important*

   a. fresh b. conscious c. multiple

2. a noun meaning *an effect or an influence*

   a. behaviour b. strategy c. impact

3. a noun meaning *a general feeling that you get from a person or place*

   a. vibe b. effort c. wardrobe

4. a noun meaning *a time when an important change takes place in a situation, especially one that makes it better*

   a. turning point b. wage c. joy

5. a noun meaning *someone who is looking at things in a shop without being sure whether they want to buy anything*

   a. unfollower b. author c. browser

6. an adjective meaning *liked or wanted by most people*

   a. popular b. desirable c. actual

Published by Macmillan Education Ltd. © Macmillan Education Limited, 2023.

PHOTOCOPIABLE CAN BE DOWNLOADED FROM WEBSITE

The Guardian

one stop english

How to quit fast fashion: 'Sometimes we don't need retail therapy, we need actual therapy'

Level 3: Intermediate

7. a noun meaning *a set of principles that people use to decide what is right and what is wrong*

   a. ethics b. therapy c. habits

8. a noun meaning *a sudden strong feeling of fear or worry that makes you unable to think clearly or calmly*

   a. purchase b. principle c. panic

9. a verb meaning *take part in a particular activity*

   a. deliver b. satisfy c. engage

10. a verb meaning *change, especially used to talk about an idea, attitude or plan*

    a. shift b. notice c. fit

Published by Macmillan Education Ltd. © Macmillan Education Limited, 2023.

PHOTOCOPIABLE CAN BE DOWNLOADED FROM WEBSITE

The Guardian

one stop english

How to quit fast fashion: 'Sometimes we don't need retail therapy, we need actual therapy'

Level 3: Intermediate

Lucianne Tonti
28 November, 2022

1 Fast-fashion brands have sold the promise of a shiny new outfit resulting in happiness for more than two decades, but most of us recognize that happiness is not what they give us. But breaking up with fast fashion can be difficult, even for the most conscious buyer.

2 According to psychologist Chris Cheers, sometimes the first step to changing your behaviour is noticing the beliefs underneath it. "So maybe your belief is, 'If I don't buy this, I can't go to that party,'" he says. The key is to notice the thought and understand you don't have to believe it.

3 Cheers says if your brain is suggesting you'll be more popular or desirable in the new purchase, think about what really happens. Is a new top going to get you the meaningful life that you want? "Sometimes we don't need retail therapy, we need actual therapy," he says.

4 There are some strategies you can use to change your buying habits. Here, people who no longer buy fast fashion share their tips.

The rule of three

5 In 2019, Lauren Bravo, the author of How To Break Up With Fast Fashion, decided to not buy anything "new-new" for a year. She made the decision after she panic-bought five dresses (and sent four back). She says that realizing none of those dresses really satisfied her need was a turning point.

6 Now she never buys anything new without thinking it over for weeks or months. She researches the brand's ethics and only buys from brands who pay their workers a decent wage. She considers how an item will fit into her existing wardrobe. And she uses her mum's rule: before you buy anything, name at least three items in your wardrobe you would wear it with, and three (real) places or occasions you will wear it to. She also believes in the joy of saving up for something.

The unfollower

7 Writer and podcaster Maggie Zhou follows several principles. "One is the '30 Wears' rule, where I ideally want to wear an item of clothing at least 30 times."

The no-buy browser

8 She has made an effort to change her digital activity: unfollowing fast-fashion brands on social media and unsubscribing from email lists. But the biggest shift was a realization that "style actually comes from re-wearing and re-styling clothes in multiple ways."

9 "I know myself, and I know I'm not going to stop shopping," says Wendy Syfret, author of The Sunny Nihilist. Instead of browsing online shops, she now browses non-shopping platforms like Pinterest and Instagram. "I make boards and saved folders of looks I like or brands I'm interested in," she says.

10 She tries to ask bigger questions of herself, so style is not about being "fresh" and "new" all the time. Instead, she tries to focus on the person she wants to be and the vibe she wants to project.

The educated switcher

11 "It's not so much that I have a strategy for avoiding fast fashion," says Nico Idour, "I just do not engage anymore." The owner of Jawbreaker the Baker has changed his shopping habits since meeting his husband, designer Jason Hewitt. Hewitt explained the "realities of fast fashion" and the huge environmental costs of mass production and international shipping. Quitting fast fashion was easy for Idour once he understood the environmental impact.

12 Now he only shops second-hand. He also has a rule that he must try something on before he buys it, which stops him from making sudden purchases online.

© Guardian News and Media 2022
First published in The Guardian, 28/11/2022

Published by Macmillan Education Ltd. © Macmillan Education Limited, 2023.

PHOTOCOPIABLE CAN BE DOWNLOADED FROM WEBSITE

The Guardian

one stop english

How to quit fast fashion: 'Sometimes we don't need retail therapy, we need actual therapy'

Level 3: Intermediate

3 Comprehension check

a. Who said it? Read the sentences below and write the name of who said them.

1. Change what you do online and stop following fashion brands and influencers on social media.
2. Not everything you think or first believe is true.
3. Learn about damage to the environment that fast fashion is responsible for.
4. Look at and save images online instead of shopping.
5. Look at the beliefs that make you want to shop more.
6. Always try an item on before you buy it and buy only second-hand.
7. Learn to wear and style the same clothes differently for different occasions.
8. Check brand ethics before you buy.
9. Style is more about who you want to be than wearing the latest fashions.
10. Before buying an item, think of what in your wardrobe you'd wear it with and where you'd wear it to.

4 Key language

a. Complete the entries with prepositions from the article.

1. break _____ : end a relationship
2. result _____ : cause something; produce something
3. think _____ : consider a problem or decision carefully
4. save _____ : regularly put money in a bank or invest it so that you can use it later
5. interested _____ : wanting to know about or take part in something
6. focus _____ : concentrate; pay particular attention to something

b. Choose three phrases from task A and write questions about clothes or fashion. Ask and answer your questions with a partner.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Published by Macmillan Education Ltd. © Macmillan Education Limited, 2023.

PHOTOCOPIABLE CAN BE DOWNLOADED FROM WEBSITE

The Guardian

one stop english

How to quit fast fashion: 'Sometimes we don't need retail therapy, we need actual therapy'

Level 3: Intermediate

5 Discussion

a. Discuss the following statements.

- "People should have the right to buy cheap clothes, even if it is bad for the environment."
- "You don't really need more than five pairs of shoes."
- "There should be more places to buy second-hand clothes."

6 In your own words

a. Write an email to a friend telling them about the article. Follow the steps below.

1. Explain what the article is about.
2. Explain why the topic is important.
3. Say if you thought it was a good article or not. Give reasons.
4. Invite your friend to read it.

Published by Macmillan Education Ltd. © Macmillan Education Limited, 2023.

PHOTOCOPIABLE CAN BE DOWNLOADED FROM WEBSITE